For too long we have looked at media materials— be they film, or television, or print, as if they exist in isolated, hermetic universes. This mode of analysis that sees ‘cinema as cinema alone’ and that does not take into account the networked information world inhabited and created by viewers, readers, audiences and producers of media materials through a constant process of interactive, cross-referential and self-referential iteration of media objects, is totally inadequate when it comes to the task of understanding the place of images, sounds, words and information that attempt to express the contemporary realities we live in.

It is important to remember that on seeing the pictures of the bodies of the slain alleged ‘terrorists’ who entered the precincts of the Parliament building on the morning of 13 December, the then home minister Lal Krishna Advani is said to have remarked that the assailants ‘looked like Pakistani terrorists’. Advani must have known what he was talking about (at least the part about their looking like ‘Pakistanis’) since he looks a lot like a Pakistani himself (as do many North Indians and migrants to India—like Advani—from the provinces of British India that became West Pakistan in 1947). But more importantly, he was able to assert the fact that they looked ‘like . . . terrorists’. It is important to pause and consider how exactly we know that someone looks like a ‘terrorist’. The Delhi Police, which has had considerable experience in handling ‘terrorists’ and ‘terrorism’ over the years, has reminded us in a series of thoughtful public service advertisements that ‘terrorists’ are suspicious because they stand out by virtue of their somewhat unusual appearance and behaviour (they wear clothing unsuited to the weather, etc.), and that simultaneously they are suspicious precisely because they blend in so easily with the general population. It is this combination of ‘standing out’ and ‘blending in’ at the same time that causes alarm. It is possible to say that one can’t quite make out if a person ‘stands out’ if he/she ‘blends in’ at the same time. But to this, like Advani, we know that we can respond with certainty, because we feel we know that when we see a ‘terrorist’ we will be able to recognize one. After all, we have ‘seen’ people who convincingly embody ‘terrorism’ many times. We have seen them on identikit photographs pasted on to walls and street corners, we have seen their disfigured, hooded and blurred faces in newspaper and magazine photographs and television reports, and we have seen them up close countless times in mainstream cinema. We have seen the face of the terrorist so often, and so intimately as a moving image, that in a sense the terrorist actually lives in our